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September 17, 2026

Do Flock cameras actually reduce crime? The jury is still out.

A recent study on how Flock cameras influence crime rates has limitations that prevent firm conclusions from being drawn.

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A Flock camera in Arlington, Virginia.

A [recent working paper by scholars at the University of South Carolina](#) examined the impact of Flock Safety’s automated license plate readers (ALPRs) on car theft and

A closer look, however, reveals limitations in the study that suggest those claims are too strong. To add context and further inform public debate on the issue, the Institut

Clearance rates for car theft were increasing and car thefts were decreasing *before* ALPR deployment

The working paper compares car theft and clearance rates in cities that deployed Flock ALPRs (the “treatment group”) with those that did not (the “control group”). It fir

The problem is that trends in the treatment group were already heading in the right direction for both thefts and clearance rates *before* Flock deployment, when comparec

“Because there were already differences in arrests and theft trends *before* ALPR deployment, we don’t know if the differences after ALPR deployment were caused by A

The headline result on car theft depends heavily on how the data are weighted

The study only achieves its topline finding of an 11% reduction in car theft by weighting the results to favor agencies that had higher amounts of car theft before they ins

Further muddying the picture, any effects are not even uniform among agencies that had high levels of car theft before Flock deployment—as most agencies that adopted the upshot is that the topline 11% figure, even if causal, does not describe what happened in many if not most agencies that deployed Flock ALPRs.

Social factors further complicate the analysis

The study period included both the COVID-19 pandemic and the viral trend of Kia and Hyundai thefts. Both phenomena affected crime at different times, in different places. “Flock and its supporters are trying to exploit fear of crime to convince people to give up their rights,” said IJ Attorney Michael Soyfer. “Notably absent from the conversation is the lack of those protections means ALPR technology can be easily abused, as IJ has [documented hundreds of times](#). Our [Plate Privacy Project](#) is challenging the government. To dig deeper into the limitations of the data on ALPR deployment and crime, [read the full explainer prepared by IJ’s Strategic Research team](#).

Is Government Tracking Your Every Move?

IJ is fighting to restore constitutional limits on surveillance — for every American.

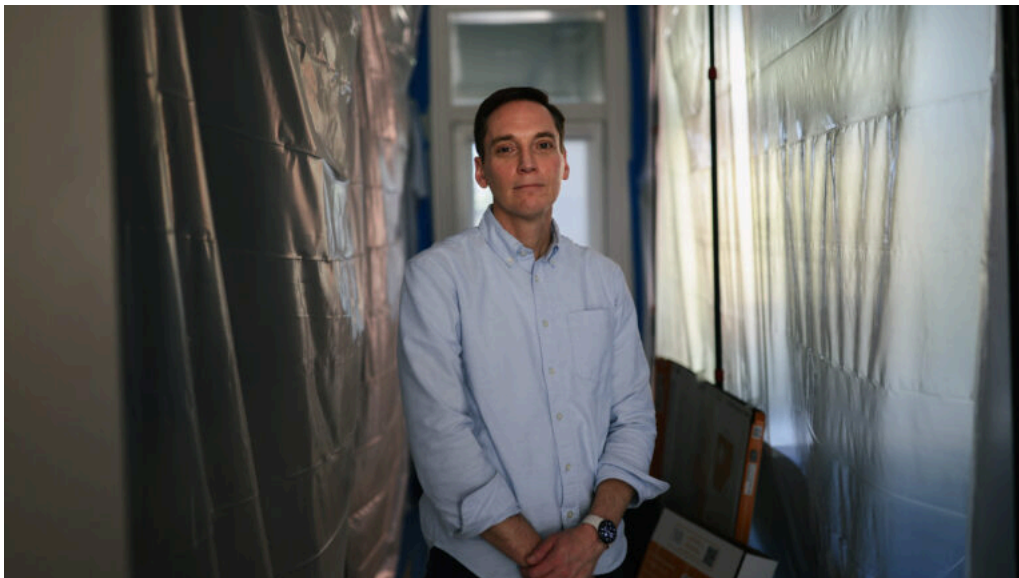
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